

wide sensors are now 48MP. By default, you also get the option to click 12MP, 24MP or 48MP shots.

The Galaxy S26, on the other hand, offers a triple-camera setup, with a 50MP main sensor, a 12MP ultra-wide, and a 10MP 3x telephoto lens.

In good light, the iPhone 17 produces sharper images with better detail retention, especially in textures. However, it leans slightly towards warmer tones. Samsung's images are more vibrant and tuned for social media, though sometimes this comes at the cost of fine detail, particularly in elements like hair texture and details.

That said, low-light photography is an area where Samsung takes it away from the iPhone. The Galaxy S26 captures more detail and handles darker scenes more effectively. Also, I like the fact that it didn't try to artificially make the sky 'bluer'.

The biggest advantage for the Galaxy S26 is in zoom and portraits. The dedicated 3x telephoto lens allows for better framing, more natural background blur, and greater flexibility. As a result, portraits look better and background blur is more natural.

However, when it comes to the ultra-wide camera, this is a major improvement on the iPhone 17 this year. In comparison, I found the ultra-wide images taken on the iPhone to be sharper. Edge distortion was also pretty minimal, and the overall quality is great. Samsung's ultra-wide camera is also good, but again, the iPhone does it slightly better.

For selfies, the iPhone 17 produces more natural-looking results with accurate skin tones. However, the Galaxy S26 is better at handling HDR. Where I would give the iPhone 17's selfie camera an edge is in the fact that it is Centre-Stage. This means, it gives you the versatility to fit more into the frame. That said, quality wise, despite the iPhone producing more natural results, the selfies on the S26 look more appealing.

Finally, video recording is one area where Apple still remains the undis-



puted champion. Stabilisation, colour accuracy, and overall consistency are still better on the iPhone, even though Samsung offers higher resolution options like 8K recording, while the other lenses support 4K at 60fps.

## Battery and charging

Battery performance is where expectations are usually high with flagships. But, since these are 'compact' flagships, especially with 120Hz displays and AI features, your mileage will vary depending on what kind of user you are.

The iPhone 17 features a 3,692mAh battery, which may sound underwhelming at first, but in actual usage, it performs surprisingly well. The main reason for this is the fact that iOS is not as resource-hungry as Android.

In testing, the iPhone 17 delivered around 22 hours of video playback, which is excellent. In daily use, with social media, camera, and streaming, I was getting 6 to 7 hours of screen-on time, when charging up to 80 per cent.

On the other hand, the Galaxy S26 comes with a larger 4,300mAh battery, and that shows in consistency. If you use your phone moderately, it will comfortably last a full day, and by the time you are in bed, you will still have around 10 per cent battery left.

For those who care about numbers, in the PCMark battery test, the Galaxy S26 got 16 hours and 30 minutes of screen-on time.

As for the charging, both phones support 25W wired charging, and in my testing, both took roughly 1 hour and 15 minutes to go from 0 to 100 per cent. Wireless charging is also available on both, but the iPhone 17 gets faster speeds at 25W with proper MagSafe. While the Galaxy S26 only get 15W wireless with no MagSafe.

## Verdict

The choice between an iPhone and a Galaxy has never been easy. But, at least, for the first time in years, this comparison feels genuinely balanced.

I would say the standard iPhone is no longer just a 'safe' option. In fact, if you get the iPhone 17, this one is a complete flagship with strong optimisation, reliable cameras, consistent performance, and finally, a 120Hz display.

The Galaxy S26, however, still offers more in terms of features. It has a brighter 120Hz display, more versatile cameras, higher peak performance, and more capable AI features.

So, let me put it this way for you. If you want a phone that feels stable, refined, and consistent every day, the iPhone 17 makes more sense. But, if you prefer more power, flexibility, and features packed into a compact flagship, the Galaxy S26 is the better choice.

Basically, it's not at all about which one is better overall; it's about which approach suits your usage more. Either way, I don't think you will be disappointed with your purchase. **T**

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